

out and pay your college tuition and buy your books, but we expect you to do your part,” her father said. “If you don’t keep your grades up, we’ll stop helping. What’s the matter? You’re capable of doing better work.”

Naomi was shattered. She had always had the approval of her parents, and now they were putting pressure on her too. An event that very evening became the final straw. She came home at about 6:00 p.m. from classes, almost on the verge of tears because of the earlier discussion with her father. She opened the door, flipped on the light switch and—nothing happened. She made her way to the dining room and tried that switch. Still nothing. Finally she realized that their power had been turned off.

She found a flashlight and began to look through the desk in their bedroom, where she found two delinquent notices that warned that their electricity would be turned off if the bill wasn’t paid immediately. She also found similar notices from the gas and water companies. She sat there in the dark, shaking, until Ben came home.

When Ben came in she heard, “Naomi, what’s the matter with the lights?”

“I’ll tell you what’s the matter! You haven’t paid the bill, and they’ve turned our power off. That’s what’s the matter! And ... I found notices from the other utilities too. Ben, what’s going on? Can’t we even keep up with the utility bills?”

“I’m sorry. I meant to pay them, but there wasn’t enough money in the last paycheck. I’ll try to get caught up next paycheck.”

“It’s always the next paycheck with you. But we never seem to have enough money to catch up. I’m going to quit school and get a full-time job. I just can’t live like this anymore.”

“I’m really sorry ... but I think you’re right. If you could just work for a while until we get caught up, it really would help. You should be able to go back next fall. I’ve got another raise coming that will help a lot then.”

Naomi quit school and was able to move up to full-time hours with Wagner Design. She had been accustomed to tithing her